



Qatar Foundation's Education City – Early capacity building for an education hub[☆]

Dennis C. Roberts

New Dimensions in Education – Independent Consultant, 720 LaCrosse Avenue, Wilmette, IL 60091, USA

ARTICLE INFO

Keywords:

Educational innovation
Capacity building
Knowledge diplomacy
Professionalization
Student engagement
Cultural learning

ABSTRACT

The author's insights regarding the early phase of establishing education partnerships is based on serving Qatar Foundation from 2007 to 2014 as its Education City grew in number of institutions, student enrollment, and complexity of functions. Maturing as a hub capable of stimulating new knowledge and innovation required cultivating cooperation and mutual benefit with its partners and fostering community among faculty, staff, and students. Conditions the author found essential included cultural learning and dexterity, critical examination of educational practices, building shared capacity, and agreeing to and measuring desired outcomes.

1. Introduction

Qatar Foundation began in 1995 and welcomed its first university partner in 1998. Fulfilling the far-reaching vision of His Highness the Father Emir Sheikh Hamad Bin Khalifa Al-Thani and Her Highness Sheikha Moza bint Nasser, Education City emerged as an education hub including the K-12 Qatar Academy, eight U.S. and European university partners, a variety of essential facilities designed to serve its partner institutions separately and together, and eventually resulting in the creation of the multidisciplinary graduate school, Hamad Bin Khalifa University. As a not-for-profit organization, Qatar Foundation established a unique ecosystem “supported by partnerships with leading international institutions” with a commitment to “addressing Qatar’s most pressing challenges; creating local, regional, and global impact; and empowering people to shape both the present and the future” (<https://www.qf.org.qa/about>).

I was privileged to serve Qatar Foundation as Assistant Vice President for Education in the formative years of building Education City. The focus of this role was on serving Qatar’s interests through cooperative ventures with Qatar Foundation’s university partners. Having been away from Qatar for ten years, many things have changed. However, I offer my reflections on the process while I was involved, highlighting the dynamics of an emerging and complex educational organization. My reflections should be considered with an understanding that I am an enthusiast for what Qatar Foundation has done, believing that its boundary-breaking initiative can be instructive for others. At the same

time, I recognize the enormous human and financial commitment that it took to create Education City, a level of dedication that could be challenging to replicate elsewhere.

My focus in this summary is on the process and dynamics of setting up a multi-partner international education hub. Issues that are addressed include establishing the purposes of the Qatar Foundation project, attracting institutional partners, defining working relationship, and anticipating outcomes and prospects for sustainability. My work in student affairs is a particularly noteworthy aspect of the Qatar Foundation approach, resulting in both promising and challenging dynamics. Student affairs administration is often viewed as a subsidiary dimension of western approaches to higher education (Schreiber et al., 2023). I differ in believing that enriching student learning and development in and out of class is one of the most important attributes of a high-quality institution or hub. The challenge is convincing institutional partners to make the student experience a priority, creating a shared approach, and cultivating expertise to make it happen.

Qatar Foundation’s successes are impressive. Education City now enrolls over 3500 students in seven partner university academic programs including Virginia Commonwealth University, Cornell University, Texas A&M University, Carnegie Mellon University, Georgetown University, Northwestern University, and HEC Paris. Only one institution, University College of London, is no longer involved. The partner programs have graduated over 7000 students from 1998 to the present. The eighth institution, Hamad Bin Khalifa University, includes multidisciplinary graduate programs that enroll over nine hundred students of

[☆] Former Qatar Foundation – Assistant Vice President for Education.

E-mail address: dcroberts48@gmail.com.

seventy nationalities, over one quarter being Qatari nationals. The Education City website boasts of being the home to “some of the world’s leading educational institutes, a homegrown research university, start-up incubators, technology parks, heritage sites, cultural institutions, and so much more.” (<https://www.qf.org.qa/education/education-city>).

The successes of Education City are potentially instructive as governments and institutions consider the prospects of establishing education hubs throughout the world. Following reflections on cultural issues in education hub initiatives, different types of hubs are described, Education City’s purposes and approaches are summarized, and the early stages of building an education hub are explained. The final focus of this article includes exploration of potential outcomes and the discernment of successes and missed opportunities that I observed during my years of service to Qatar Foundation.

2. Cultural expectation and dexterity

Before describing the espoused purpose of Education City and how Qatar attracted the partners to fulfill its vision, it is critical to understand the cultural dynamics of such an initiative. Qatar is a sovereign nation on a peninsula that juts out into the Arabia Gulf from its shared land border with Saudi Arabia. It was never officially colonized but was a protectorate of Great Britain from 1916 until 1971. Even after gaining independence from Great Britain, it maintained close ties through trade and diplomatic relations. The economy of Qatar benefited from the discovery of the North Field gas reservoir and the accompanying extraction and transport of natural gas over the following two decades (Ibrahim and Harrigan, 2012). Qatar is a rentier economy, with the employment of its people dependent on the extraction of massive hydrocarbon resources, the result of which is it being the world’s largest supplier of liquid natural gas (LNG) and gas to liquid (GTL) fuels.

The above brief summary, along with Qatar’s contemporary economic and political positioning, is important because it is foundational to the pride in recent progress prevalent among its residents. Clearly, the country and its people benefit from numerous business and educational initiatives that may look as if it is “westernizing.” While there is some evidence that supports this view, Qatar maintains diplomatic and cultural ties outside western influencers that include other Gulf, Asian region, and African continent governments. Maintaining connections with numerous governments and cultures is coupled with the assertion by Qatar’s leadership of the dignity and worth of its people and their cultural legacy. Fundamental to this pride is Qatar’s commitment to Islamic religious beliefs and insistence on maintaining conventions of personal and business conduct informed by it.

2.1. More than accommodation

Qatar’s history and present position in the world require considerable cultural dexterity (Molinsky, 2013) for any individual or organizations that seeks to be successful in educational partnerships. This dexterity is more than awareness or accommodation. Cultural responsiveness in this case means deeply understanding the customs and values of Qatar and its people, assessing where and to what degree a prospective partner may be different in relation to these customs and values, and engaging in ways that acknowledge difference, show respect, offer value based on the prospective partner’s views, and seeking partnership that benefits all stakeholders.

2.2. Research on culture

Hofstede (1984) and the GLOBE studies (House et al., 2004) have contributed to the success of for-profit organizations by encouraging greater awareness of how cultural differences impact the way prospective partners or clients are approached. This has helped to avoid blunders but has perhaps also encouraged over-generalization and

stereotypes (Roberts and Yamanaka, 2023, Zander, 2020). Avoiding the categorization of cultures, Zander simply asserted that to be successful, leadership outside of western environments should focus on respect and protection of unique cultures, mutual benefit, and the triple benefits of pursuing profit, coupled with protecting the environment and improving the human condition of all (Zander, 2020).

Reviewing research studies such as these are helpful to anyone who seeks to work in a cross-cultural setting. If assumptions and stereotypes are avoided, they can provide a starting place for assessing one’s own cultural inclinations and stimulating interest in working to adapt or demonstrate dexterity in order to be effective. However, the lived experience of working in another culture reveals a deeper reality – cultural learning and proficiency is a continuing commitment throughout the experience of working across culture or living and working in an international education hub setting.

2.3. Negotiating customs and values

While I constantly sought insightful reading about the history and culture of Qatar, it was the cumulative experience and the coaching of Qatari colleagues along the way that made the difference in my effectiveness. I was fortunate to have several Qatari and other Arab colleagues who I could ask for, and who regularly offered, insights on culture that were essential in both personal and professional endeavors. Working directly for Qatar Foundation was very different from the experience of working for a hub partner, primarily due to most of my colleagues being Qatari and Arab or Indian expatriate workers. Hub partner employees generally lacked the opportunity for this level of grounded learning. As my experience unfolded, I found that I was most successful in negotiating cultural landscapes when I considered the three elements of customs, values, and tolerance.

The *customs*, or conventional habits and patterns of behavior, that are most obvious in Qatar were related to common cordiality and ritual. An example in greetings is that there were conventions that were different for men and women. The greetings for Qatari men to one another were very ritualistic, usually involving a handshake or even more intimate, bumping of noses. While non-Qatari men greeting Qatari did not include this level of cordiality, a welcoming handshake was certainly expected, and direct eye contact engendered another level of sincerity. Greetings among women were very warm, with almost every greeting appearing to be familial. Some women would exchange polite handshakes with men, but for most the custom was simply to place one’s right hand over the heart. Viewing these differences as indicative of sexism and demonstrations of imbalance in power is common among visitors or newcomers but actual conduct of male and female colleagues demonstrates otherwise.

In relation to business custom, being introduced to a Qatari colleague by a go-between acquaintance was common and barging in unannounced was considered disrespectful. Once appointments were secured, most encounters started with exchange of personal information about unrelated interests and then gradually proceeded to the business of the day. The prevailing sense of welcome and cordiality could be misunderstood by emissaries from some cultures who thought they were driving toward a conclusion in business dealings. Conversation with Qatari and other Arab colleagues is typically cordial but may in fact reach no commitment at all.

Values, which are reflections of core beliefs, are more deeply grounded in both historic and contemporary experiences and therefore warrant greater attention. Family is central to the lives of all Qatari and spending time with them and catering to their needs is paramount. This meant that working late into the evening, or especially on weekends, was uncommon for both Qatari and expatriates. Religious observances are very strong which means that the day of prayer, Friday in the Qatar case, was reserved for private observance. Humility is expected of all and westerners prone to boasting or dominating others may engender disrespect. Another reflection of humility is found in dress. Most Qatari

nationals wear traditional clothing, thawb (pronounced “thobe”) for men and abaya/hijab for women, but westerners observed contemporary styles found in Asian, European, and U.S. urban environments. Both men and women are expected to observe modesty in dress.

Breaking with a custom is relatively easy to excuse as a blunder, while violating core values is a different matter. Negotiating cultural expectations is also heavily impacted by the *tolerance* for difference, or the degrees of distance from one person’s culture to another. When comparing U.S. versus Arab world environments, U.S. expectations are more porous or flexible while Arab conventions are more defined and predictable. Striking a comfortable place on the continuum from soft to hard culture then is a matter of discretion with my experience being that heightened awareness and accommodation on my part was usually most effective, if the accommodation didn’t violate my own values.

Having hosted or spoken to multiple groups about Qatar Foundation and Education City over the years I served in Qatar, I came to see the sophisticated stereotypes of which Zander (2020) warned as having a more pernicious cousin – judging or exoticizing culture. When I first moved to Qatar, I was often confounded by questions from colleagues in the U.S. who asked about whether I felt safe living there. I was bewildered because the reality was that I was safer in Qatar than most U.S. cities. Then I started noticing social media posts from those living or traveling abroad, which frequently drew many “likes” or comments and the more exotic the setting appeared, the more numerous the response. Portraying cross-cultural experiences as exotic stimulates lots of reaction in conversation or clicks on social media, but it exaggerates and perpetuates tensions between cultures rather than bridging them.

The two most essential qualities required to be successful in negotiating customs and values are humility and curiosity. The greater the cultural difference between oneself and the setting one visits or where one works the more awareness, negotiation, and adaption that is required. Minor adaptations are likely easier to see in the first place while deeper differences may be more obscure, the result of being deeply held values. Instead of responding with judgment when encountering cultural differences, the first step is to seek understanding about the origin or cause of the difference. Once humility is introduced in cross-cultural exchange, curiosity begins to drive subsequent and deeper interactions. The combination of both humility and curiosity then earns the trust of others and results in greater degrees of freedom in adapting as well as forgiveness when a cultural custom or value is inadvertently violated.

3. Qatar Foundation’s Education City

3.1. Knowledge and capacity building

Using the models advocated elsewhere in this issue, Qatar’s Education City reflects the qualities Knight (2014) describes in the knowledge/innovation hub and conforms to elements of Porter’s (1998) industry cluster description. I provide brief summaries of these models and explain how Education City compares to each below.

3.2. International education hubs

Knight (2014) has been highly instrumental in analyzing and differentiating the types of international higher education hubs and concluded that there are three common models. “*The Student Hub* is the most focused and prevalent type of education hub. The key activity is the education and training of local, expatriate, and international students” (p. 7). The second type, “*The Talent Hub* focuses on student education and training but differs from the Student Hub because the overarching goal is to develop a skilled work force” (p. 8). “*The Knowledge/Innovation Hub* broadens its mandate beyond education and training to include the production and distribution of knowledge and innovation” (p. 8) is the third model.

These three approaches to international hubs require different levels

of commitment of fiscal, physical, and human resources. Knowledge/innovation hubs require significant collaboration among both “foreign and local institutions, industries, research centres, and companies” (Knight, 2014). The focus of knowledge/innovation hubs includes 1) building knowledge and service-based economies, 2) educating and training for knowledge creation and innovation, 3) attracting foreign investment, and 4) increasing regional and global competitiveness in economic influence and soft power (Knight, 2014). Knight’s (2022) later work differentiated soft power from knowledge diplomacy, noting that soft power is the most commonly used term but implies an imbalance in power and benefit that may not be desirable if true partnership is sought. By contrast, knowledge diplomacy in international higher education is “the process of building and strengthening relations between and among countries through international higher education, research, and innovation” (Knight, 2022). Mutual benefit and reciprocity are foundational to the intent of knowledge diplomacy.

The Education City hub partners were initially drawn together as a student hub but, as these programs matured, they evolved to become a knowledge/innovation hub. Each partner was selected based on the fit of the specific academic program to the talent and capacity building needs of the country and region. Because no one institution has uniform excellence in all subject areas, separate university partners were identified that were recognized for being among the best in the particular academic program they would offer in Qatar. For example: Virginia Commonwealth University offers programs in art and design; Weill Cornell offers a six-year medical degree, Texas A&M focuses on engineering; Carnegie Mellon University offers programs in biological science, business administration, computer science, and information systems; Georgetown University offers programs in international relations and foreign affairs; Northwestern University offers programs in media and communication; and HEC Paris provides executive education for management and leadership. The undergraduate programs each offer foundation or liberal education courses as well as the specialized courses required for completion of the major. All course and degree requirements are the same as the home campus and degrees are granted from the home institution.

In addition to the preparation of graduates to serve in critical workforce need areas, each of the hub programs conducts ongoing research and capacity building in partnership with various businesses and economic sectors. As an example, the first partner program in art and design with Virginia Commonwealth University provides annual art and fashion exhibitions that are open to the public and graduates are encouraged to engage in entrepreneurial efforts, with some of their products sold in the VCU book and convenience shop in their building. The engineering program of Texas A&M conducts extensive research, much of it concentrated in the oil and gas sector. Students are actively engaged as research assistants and have promising careers in Qatar’s energy producing companies once they graduate.

While the focus of this article is on higher education, the facilities and programs available at Qatar Foundation’s Education City go far beyond its eight university programs and the graduate programs of Hamad Bin Khalifa University. The 12 square kilometer campus includes three national research centers, 5000+ funded research projects, startups, patent innovation, the Qatar National Library, a convention center, sports and recreation (including a soccer stadium), residence halls, art museum, equine center, and more (<https://www.qf.org.qa/>). All these facilities are purpose-built and plotted in a park-like setting with transportation provided via tram. Formal and informal spaces encourage interdependence by drawing programs and people together throughout the shared campus.

The genius of placing so many resources in close proximity is how both planned and serendipitous interaction can result in new relationships or ideas emerging within a highly creative, international and intercultural environment. Qatar’s success in creating a knowledge/innovation hub is self-evident, however, the degree to which knowledge diplomacy is underway is a work in progress, or at least was a work in

progress at the time I served in Qatar. Considering Knight's (2002) conditions for knowledge diplomacy, the governments in which the hub programs operate their home campus are actively engaged in diplomacy to be sure. However, the relationship between the respective governments and their higher education sector's commitment to mutually beneficial knowledge diplomacy was unclear.

3.3. Clusters

Porter's (1998) "Clusters and the new economics of competition," article indicates that "Clusters affect competition in three broad ways: first, by increasing the productivity of companies based in the area; second, by driving the direction and pace of innovation, which underpins future productivity growth; and third, by stimulating the formation of new businesses, which expands and strengthens the cluster itself" (Porter, 1998).

Graduates of Education City programs who are Qatari take positions in various employment sectors with international students often seeking to gain employment and work visas to remain in Qatar after they graduate. Such an investment in supporting talent development and then retaining graduates for Qatar's workforce contributes to enhancing the productivity of numerous entities. The network of graduates from Education City then creates linkages throughout Qatar's economic and service landscape. Using these indices, it is clear that Qatar Foundation offers the cluster benefit that Porter described. While Education City began with the vision of improving access and quality of educational opportunity, it has expanded to benefit numerous other sectors.

Porter specifically mentioned tourism as one type of beneficiary of clusters that create:

"a whole greater than the sum of its parts. In a typical tourism cluster, for example, the quality of a visitor's experience depends not only on the appeal of the primary attraction but also on the quality and efficiency of complementary businesses such as hotels, restaurants, shopping outlets, and transportation facilities. Because members of the cluster are mutually dependent, good performance by one can boost the success of the others" (Porter, 1998).

Qatar's success in hosting the 2022 FIFA World Cup stands out as an achievement such as Porter describes. In the build-up to 2022, both Qatari and expatriate graduates of Education City were hired into direct service or management roles in government and non-government entities, museum and cultural institutions, transportation and logistics, and the hospitality and entertainment industry. The fact that the 2022 FIFA World Cup was the first in the Arab world, incorporating cultural celebration and an open welcome to all, was a victory for Qatar and all those who contributed to it.

While Qatar has achieved status as a significant contributor to energy needs around the world, it has gained other competitive advantages in the overall global economy. By building a concentration of educational institutions and relating them to local employment capacity building it has linked "highly specialized skills and knowledge, institutions, rivals, related businesses, and sophisticated customers" (Porter, 1998) together in an ideal mix to spur further innovation in the future.

Reinforcing the importance of cultural dexterity, Porter found that "the manifold social connections among economic actors and the culture of particular places play important roles in shaping economic behaviors such as risk-taking, cooperation, and information-sharing" (Porter, 1998). This view confirms both my personal experience as well as observation of others who sought to benefit from the cluster synergies made possible at Education City.

4. Early stages of partnering

I joined Qatar Foundation in November of 2007 after the earliest work began in 1995. I was there as new partner programs joined, buildings were designed and completed, and as the working

relationships were refined between university partners and Qatar Foundation's Education Division. My role, Assistant Vice President for Education – Faculty and Student Services, was scoped by a consultant's report documenting key needs recommended by hub partner leadership. Specific areas in which coordination was immediately necessary were in admissions testing, recruitment, financial aid, student residences, health and counseling, security, and general student welfare. Faculty services were limited to enhancing social interaction and offering opportunities for faculty and their families to sample the local culture.

In retrospect, the creation of a coordinating position was only natural considering the expansion of the university partnerships and greater complexity involved as student numbers increased. While it was natural for the intent and breadth of the Qatar Foundation initiative to enlarge with experience and time, the absence of an expectation for collaboration among the partners meant that the cooperative endeavor had to be cultivated, which wasn't always easy. Each partner was invited to Qatar in confidential agreements that were unique to their program, all requiring that the academic experience of the hub program would be equivalent to that of students at the home campus. How the partners would work with each other and what was expected in terms of cooperative venture with Qatar Foundation was less precise.

It is important to understand from the beginning that prospective partners' motivations for joining in a hub vary from extending their brand, to financial benefits, to the potential of enriching a breadth of student outcomes on the main campus and at the remote site. Openly recognizing these motivations provides the opportunity to achieve shared expectations and defined objectives. Provision of start-up budgets and temporary facilities are important as partners begin, assuming that budgets will need to be adjusted and should eventually stabilize over time with greater predictability from year to year. Budgets are heavily dependent on physical facilities, whether they are shell spaces versus purpose-built to conform to partner's preferences, including laboratories or other experiential spaces, and the variability in instructional costs across academic disciplines. Opportunities to review agreements and time limits for the partnership should also be specified. The ten-year cycle of review and renewal of agreements for Education City partnerships was enough time for routines to be established before consideration of renewal.

The early stages of relationship development are fraught with opportunities for misunderstandings. Particularly with faculty and staff from U.S. or European institutions, a sense of privilege related to their credentials and status can be challenging. The entitlement that comes with being selected for such a venture can result in expectations that go beyond what the host country or organization anticipated. There are two levels of anticipation – at the institutional and at the individual level. The institutional level is more easily managed because details can be specified in agreements and regular consultative meetings. However, the personal experiences of faculty and staff who work for the partner do not offer the same negotiation and renegotiation opportunity. Having both formal and informal means to gather input at the individual level is, therefore, essential. Issues that can become contentious are accommodations (whether provide or offered allowances), travel (personal and professional), classroom and office spaces, and governance and decision making.

The excitement in the start-up of an education hub can be both exhilarating and exhausting. During such a time, maintaining flexibility and recognizing the genius of placing so many resources in close proximity in both planned and serendipitous ways can result in new relationships or ideas emerging with highly creative potential.

4.1. Seeking cooperative endeavor

To achieve cooperation, hub sponsors and prospective partners should begin with an understanding that policies and practices should be carefully reviewed, and determination made to transfer, adapt, hedge, or avoid them (Roberts and Komives, 2016) to the local cultural context.

Applying or adapting practices in the classroom are important due to the different cultural environments of students who may study at an education hub. An easy example of this in the case of journalism is that many of the students who studied at the Northwestern University program came from, and would return to, cultures and political environments where freedom of the press was not possible. The idea of freedom of expression was not abandoned but how a student could pursue it was different and this was an important accommodation.

Specifically in relation to student experiences outside of the classroom, student affairs educators with training from the U.S. typically embrace ideas of self-determination, identity development, and advocacy that require critical examination and adaptation across cultures. Facilities issues such as residence halls or activities, and social and athletic programs may need to be approached very differently outside the U.S. context. Returning to the previous point in relation to tolerance for difference across cultures (see 2.3), when the cultural distance is greater, more adaptation may be warranted. In the most challenging environment, where cultural difference is significant and conditions for success are uncertain, educators might best avoid the policy or practice all together.

4.2. Foundational elements for cooperation

When I first returned from working abroad, I was invited to reflect on my experience working for Qatar Foundation (Roberts, 2015) with a focus on why internationalization was important to all institutions of higher learning. This article concluded with a list of elements that encouraged cooperation that I believe are foundational to successful education hubs:

- Cultivate shared purpose and community among partners.
- Maintain an awareness and prioritization of multiple stakeholders.
- Align internal stakeholders with common values and aims.
- Develop awareness and sensitivity to cultural differences.
- Affirm divergent approaches.
- Embrace disruptive and rapid change.
- Demonstrate stewardship of resources.
- Offer choices, not prescriptions.

These elements are most effective when partners are approached with the assumption that engaging is a privilege for both the partner institutions and host. At the heart of this assumption is recognizing for what purpose and to whose benefit was the partnership initiated in the first place (Schreiber et al., 2023). In addition, an educational hub should be recognized as an experimental effort where learning from existing models is incorporated but where there is openness to modify the partnership as it evolves. Several issues that I found important in the early days of Qatar Foundation's Education City follow.

The nature and quality of learning should be actively discussed, and alternatives explored. This includes determining the unique qualities that should be reinforced versus what is more generic or generalizable to all partners (if there are multiple institutions represented). As an example, active or experiential learning is familiar and comfortable for students from some cultural backgrounds but not others. Or another example is that activism as an outcome of learning may be anticipated and welcomed in some settings but discouraged in other contexts.

Full utilization of the expertise of both partners and host is critical to cultivating a mutual and trustful relationship. Host or local colleagues can serve as critical cultural informants as well as serve as advisors in navigating local policies and practices; everything from where to shop to securing driving privileges and more can be challenging without a local advisor. The value offered by local colleagues should also be complemented by capacity building to fulfill growing needs for educators of all types and this must be centered in the type(s) of work people in the local setting seek. Capacity building comes in many different forms, including professional development, graduate education, and

sponsorship/mentorship, and is likely to change as the hub partnership evolves.

Because of the focus of my role on student and faculty services at Education City, the initial challenge was informing colleagues of the importance of student affairs, services, and development. The focus on informing first was in response to many local as well as expatriate partner faculty and staff not having an in-depth understanding that student affairs has a significant history and has professionalized over decades of practice in U.S. higher education. The intent was to take advantage of the research, theorizing, and models that improve students' experiences and engagement as a complement to academic study while not overly professionalizing the work (Roberts, Ammigan, Roberts, and Leask, 2022). Professionalization that is not adapted to the local cultural context and excludes those who are growing in their appreciation for improved educational opportunity and experience could undermine both trust and cultivation efforts.

The Qatar Study Tour and Young Professionals Institute (Roberts and Roberts, 2012) was created to draw local colleagues into co-learning with visiting graduate students, young professionals, and faculty studying higher education and student affairs in the U.S. The visitors from the U.S. funded their travel and incidental expenses while Qatar Foundation funded the learning and professional development experience, making it available to visitors and local colleagues who joined in an intensive two-week schedule of cultural learning, review of research and literature on student learning, and work groups that generated ideas to adapt practices to the local environment. The intent of the Study Tour and Young Professionals Institute was to cultivate interest in further professional education for those working in Qatar and the broader Arabian Gulf which resulted in the creation of the QF Certificate in Student Affairs. The certificate utilized materials generated by the Study Tour and Young Professionals Institute, established mentor/protégé pairings, and encouraged ongoing learning to prepare participants for student affairs responsibilities in Qatar.

Two final foundational elements that helped establish a cooperative spirit and commitment relate to fiscal and human resources. Because budget estimates are speculative in the early days of a partnership, additional resources may need to be allocated or there may be budgeted resources that are not used. Understanding such unpredictable circumstances, it is incumbent on hub partners to not hesitate to use allotted resources but do it in a way that does not appear exploitive or wasteful. In addition, expenditures should be made with ongoing attention to achieving greater efficiency over time, including reducing per student costs, resulting in improved potential of sustainability. The final point is that I embraced a commitment to working myself out of a job from the very beginning. While this commitment could be different with hub partners wanting to stay for the longer term, the belief that capacity building is underway that will allow the host to be increasingly independent and sustaining over time places service to the host front and center in the relationship.

5. Elite brands

Attracting reputable and elite brands is a common aspiration for some education hubs. In the case of Education City, the partners were assembled by aligning priority areas for capacity building through education in Qatar with institutions that would offer a matching program with "top 10" recognition for excellence. Of course, rankings change over time but the point in targeting renowned institutions was to guarantee that the outcomes would be superior.

5.1. Partner dynamics with elite status are different

If elite or high reputation partnerships are a priority, several issues should be recognized as potentially impacting education hub dynamics. As a general principle, they require more financial enticement and include more conditions that the host will be expected to accept. A

potentially positive outcome of elite partner institutions is that prospective students may be more eager to affiliate with known brands, resulting in higher quality and greater diversity of enrollment. But this benefit may be offset by the fact that the more elite the institution, the less responsive it may be to the host's expectations. This issue of responsiveness can arise from multiple issues with one of the more substantial relating to institutional mission. Although I know of no research confirming it, my belief is that publicly funded institutions in the U.S. have missions and institutional value systems that more easily align with the public service commitment that would support an international partnership.

Specific to the work of enhancing student learning and engagement through student affairs initiatives, it is not unusual for elite institutions to vary in relation to their recognition of, and valuing, student affairs research and practice. Most of Qatar Foundation's partner institutions had few if any student affairs trained staff in the early days, although most had a pedagogical or andragogical inclination that complemented student affairs ideas. This resulted in professional in-service preparation of hub partner staff while capacity was being built among Qatari colleagues. In fortuitously positive ways, this shared learning of host and partner may have added to the mutuality of the partnerships.

6. Outcomes of hub partnerships

A commitment by educational hub hosts and partners to conditions and outcomes that fulfill the needs of all is central to positive relations and the potential of sustainability. One of the most fundamental conditions requiring attention is determining the balance between personal benefit to graduates versus the public purpose of local community capacity building. Personal benefit and community capacity building are two ends of a continuum, with obvious potential for overlap, but how the partnership might tip toward one or the other direction involve several factors which lead to potentially different outcomes.

Factors that impact outcomes include the quality of curriculum, depth of engagement in learning (Kuh, 2008), expectation for national and cultural representation in the student population, and expected retention and graduation rates. Once these factors are determined, hub partners will need to determine what adaptations of supports and curriculum are required to respond to the local context and the students who attend the hub institutions. In the Qatar example, with all the academic programs delivered in English and at very high levels of rigor, the Academic Bridge Program (ABP) was a must to prepare students whose first language was not English.

If the local context of an education hub includes a legacy of colonialism, extant knowledge and assumptions based on westernized views of history and norms associated with individualistic versus collectivist cultures should be questioned. At the most fundamental level, questioning property and resource ownership, how achievement is defined, what constitutes a satisfying life, and what societal progress looks like may need to be examined to avoid unknowingly transferring cultural views that reflect colonialist assumptions.

One of the most concrete outcomes relates to whether graduates from other countries are expected to continue residence in the host country and enter the local workforce. If retention of graduates through employment is a priority, agreeing to how they fit with workforce needs, their opportunities for citizenship, and how graduates will be involved in governance and civil society will be important. During the years I was in Qatar, such issues were a work in progress, with the 2022 FIFA World Cup likely accelerating the need to address employment and granting of work visas for non-Qatari who sought to stay in Qatar after graduation. Aligning faculty research and scholarship to the local context was also important, a critical element in moving from education hub to knowledge and innovation hub status.

If multiple partners are planned or included in an education hub, it is critical to specify the degree of transparency and cooperation that is expected of them. In the case of Qatar's Education City, the hub partners

had their own buildings, and separate faculty and staff, which resulted in students' identifying with the brand of their academic program. However, student experience included frequent interaction with those of other partner programs, much like students would interact across academic departments in a comprehensive university. In such a setting, it was important to foster a shared experience across students from all programs and this was more easily accomplished when there was an expectation of working across partners, sharing resources, and fulfilling students' natural inclination to engage with each other.

When U.S. institutions are included in hubs, it is important to understand that most of their home campuses embrace the idea that learning occurs both in and out-of-class. The distinctive quality of U.S. institutions in fostering student engagement that enriches students' learning and development is fulfilled substantially by student affairs staff who are steeped in research and theory about students' identities, their maturational journey, the importance of engagement, and a broad expectation of students' finding and expressing their own voices. How this aspect of student learning is transferred, adapted, or avoided should be carefully considered in the early stages of partnering.

A final and, perhaps one of the most important, understandings to reach is how outcomes will be measured or assessed. Outcomes and impacts in academic performance, retention, graduation, and workforce placement are easily quantified through compilation and sharing of records. Broader assessments of students' experiences related to student engagement, cultural awareness and openness, and fulfillment of international statements such as the UNESCO World Higher Education Goals framework should also be considered (Schreiber et al., 2023). The degree to which any assessment is shared with the host organization or country should be clearly defined from the beginning of the partnership.

Agreeing to conditions like these, and others unique to a given location, are important to achieving a lasting impact and to the potential of sustaining the partnership. The Yale University and National University of Singapore program was disrupted by dynamics that Wilkins (2023) described as the "Singapore-based partner desired a higher level of independence over academic standards and freedom, while the host country government had increased concerns about the public funding" (Wilkins, p. 8–9). The same article questioned if Qatar Foundation, as well as Abu Dhabi, will continue to fund their programs or if the "governments may decide to nationalize branch campuses" (Wilkins, 2023).

While at Qatar Foundation I observed no intent to nationalize the hub programs, although I frequently advised partner staff that cultural responsiveness, localization of teaching and research, and capacity building among Qatari and local expatriate staff were essential to their futures. The nationalization noted by Wilkins (2023) was achieved perhaps more innovatively by the creation of Hamad Bin Khalifa University in 2010 as part of Education City.

7. Successes and missed opportunities

A matter of subjective perception in some cases and qualitative or quantitative evidence in others, it's important to examine what worked and didn't work. The decade since leaving Qatar has allowed me to reflect from a distance about an incredibly fulfilling experience with a bit more objectivity. The following reflections are derived from lived experience coupled with distant observation rather than consultation or research since leaving Qatar.

7.1. Successes

As a general approach to increasing cooperative effort, and more specifically to enhancing the quality and depth of engagement among students, establishing an agreed philosophical and programmatic model was essential. The "Without Borders: Collaborative Statement on the Student Experience" (unpublished brochure, Hamad bin Khalifa University – Qatar Foundation, 2011) emerged from a deeply inclusive drafting process involving stakeholders from Qatar Foundation and its

hub partners. This guiding document was based on the original founding statements to which U.S. institutions generally refer when describing the purposes of student affairs work and incorporated the programs offered at Education City (Roberts, 2012). The result of the deliberations required to produce the “Without Borders” statement and its dissemination reflected one of the things students valued most – connection and engagement across hub programs. While not directly attributable to this initiative, the hub programs began offering cross-registration and new cooperative academic programs not long afterward.

One of the central commitments of student affairs work is assessment and continuous evidence-based improvement of practices. Prior to the creation of the Faculty and Student Services area within Qatar Foundation’s Education Division, no consideration had been given to assessing the student experience. Agreement to assess student experiences by utilizing the U.S. created National Survey of Student Engagement (NSSE) was achieved through cooperative effort among the hub program student affairs offices and supported by senior administration of each partner. The administration of the survey retained students’ confidentiality, allowed for both aggregated data for all Education City hub programs, disaggregation at the individual hub partner level, and led to the conclusion that students’ education and development was at or above the highest 10% of U.S. institutions (unpublished report, Office of Faculty and Student Services, 2009). There were many hoops to jump to achieve this goal, but it was essential to demonstrate the importance of assessment at Education City, the power of assessment as a guide to improving practice, and the comparison of Qatar students’ experience with partner home campuses.

Perhaps one of the most rewarding successes of the early work at Education City was the coaching and mentoring of Qatari and other colleagues on enhancing educational practice. The Qatar Study Tour and Young Professionals Institute previously described (see 4.2) was an important component of this effort as planners, hosts, and participants engaged with one another. The QF Certificate extended this professional development focus and led to several colleagues pursuing advanced graduate work and research in preparation for careers in higher education and related work.

The combination of collaborative effort, better coordination of student support services, improved communication, and assessment of progress all contributed to success in the early days of Education City which was to *enhance the learning and development experience of students*. Providing broader access to high quality higher education was the pathway to establishing a more diverse economy increasingly reliant on multiple disciplines, research, and innovation.

I had the opportunity to return for a brief visit to Qatar Foundation’s Education City in 2019. Even in the five years between my departure and return, it was astounding to see the multi-faceted purpose-built facilities and infrastructure that had been completed to accommodate an increasing number of education and innovation entities (<https://www.qf.org.qa/about>) and growing enrollment. That the foundation for a thriving knowledge and innovation community had been laid was undeniable.

7.2. Missed opportunities

Time, resources, and talent are important, and any hub must set priorities and accept the fact that the pace of change must be carefully managed. One of the aspects of the work that the Faculty and Student Services area of the Education Division did not fully complete was nurturing faculty support and coherence. For the most part, what was achieved was the provision of social and entertainment opportunity. The lack of deeper progress could have been due to not having the resources to make it happen, but it may also have been the result of partner institution reluctance to engage at a deeper level.

8. Concluding thoughts

Ten years after having left Qatar Foundation some of the initiatives we undertook remain while others do not, and that must be accepted as part of the experience of working in an education or knowledge and innovation hub environment. The reasons why certain initiatives were abandoned vary, with some attributable to their declining importance as the model evolved and others resulting from atrophy after champions were no longer present to advocate for them. In an international education hub environment, some aspects will remain, and others will be modified or ultimately rejected.

The experience of working with Qatari and hub partner faculty and staff in the formation of Education City challenged many of the assumptions I brought with me after working in U.S. higher education for 34 years. The 7 years in Qatar provided the opportunity to examine institutional context and purpose, cultural learning and adaptation, power and influence, and cooperative commitment to improving access and quality in learning at a much deeper level than I had explored before. While the insights derive from work in an education hub setting, they also intensify questions that I now have about higher education purpose and practice regardless of the setting. This is one of the greatest benefits of international hub work – it has the potential to inspire questions and innovation relevant to any higher education setting.

CRedit authorship contribution statement

Dennis Roberts: Writing – original draft, Project administration, Conceptualization.

References

- Hofstede, G., 1984. *Culture’s consequence: International differences in work-related values*. SAGE.
- House, R.J., Hanges, P.J., Javidan, M., Dorfman, P.W., Gupta, V., 2004. *Culture, leadership, and organizations: The GLOBE study of 62 societies*. SAGE.
- Ibrahim, I., Harrigan, F., 2012. Qatar’s economy: past, present and future. *QScience Connect* (1), 1–24. <https://doi.org/10.5339/connect.2012.9>.
- Knight, J., 2014. Three generations of crossborder higher education: New developments, issues, and challenges. In: Steitwieser, B. (Ed.), *Internationalization of Higher Education and Global Mobility*. Symposium Books, pp. 43–58.
- Knight, J., 2022. Knowledge diplomacy in international relations and higher education. Springer. <https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-031-14977-1>.
- Kuh, G.D. (2008). *High-impact educational practices: what they are, who has access to them, and why they matter*. Association of American Colleges and Universities.
- Molinsky, A., 2013. *Global dexterity: How to adapt your behavior across cultures without losing yourself in the process*. Harvard Business Review Press.
- Porter, M.E. (1998). Clusters and the new economics of competition. *Harvard Business Review, Government Policy and Regulation*. (<https://hbr.org/1998/11/clusters-and-the-new-economics-of-competition>).
- Roberts, D.C., 2012. The student personnel point of view as a catalyst for dialogue: 75 years and beyond. *J. Coll. Stud. Dev.* 53 (1), 2–18.
- Roberts, D.C., 2015. Internationalizing higher education and student affairs. *Campus 20* (2), 8–16. <https://doi.org/10.1002/abc.21186>.
- Roberts, D.L., Ammigan, R., Roberts, D.C., Leask, B., 2022. The student affairs profession: international perspectives. In: Deardorff, D.K., de Wit, H., Leask, B., Charles, H. (Eds.), *The handbook for international higher education*, 2nd ed. Stylus Publishing, pp. 287–305.
- Roberts, D.C., Komives, S.R., 2016. Internationalizing student learning and development (<https://doi.org/>). *N. Dir. High. Educ.* 175, 9–21. <https://doi.org/10.1002/he.20194>.
- Roberts, D.C., Roberts, D.L., 2012. Building capacity through international student affairs exchange. *J. Coll. Character* 13 (3), 2–6. <https://doi.org/10.1515/jcc-2012-1911>.
- Roberts, D.C., Yamanaka, A., 2023. International perspectives in leadership learning. In: Komives, S.R., Owen, J.E. (Eds.), *A research agenda for learning and developing leadership through higher education*. Edward Elgar Publishing, pp. 60–81.
- Schreiber, B., Roberts, D.C., & Leask, B. (2023). Looking back and looking forward. In L. B. Moscaritolo & B. Schreiber (Eds.), *Towards Professionalization of Student Affairs across the Globe, New Directions for Student Services* (pp. 115–123, 183). <https://doi.org/10.1002/ss.20486>.
- Wilkins, S., 2023. International branch campuses: current trends and future possibilities. *Int. High. Educ.* 116, 7–9. (<https://www.internationalhighereducation.net/api-v1/article/!action/getPdfOfArticle/articleID/3759/productID/29/fileName/article-id-3759.pdf>).
- Zander, L., 2020. *Research handbook of global leadership: Making a difference*. Edward Elgar Publishing.